

in time value of money, and not just the value of the underlying asset at a point in time. “Aggressive compensation mechanisms like Transfer of Development Rights (TDR), the value of which can grow over a period of time, and entitlements towards premium floor space index (FSI) with incremental value can be offered as solutions. For these, the Central and state governments need to work in tandem,” the person suggests.

GATHERING STEAM

Following the swearing in of the BJP-backed Shiv Sena faction led by Eknath Shinde in June 2022, not only land acquisition, but also the tendering activity has gone up significantly in Maharashtra. Till November-end, 98.22 per cent of land had been acquired in the western state for the project compared to 71.5 per cent on June 30, reveals an analysis of the data shared by

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NHSRCL—a special purpose vehicle of the Indian Railways—with BT. In Gujarat and Dadra and Nagar Haveli, the figure stands at 98.87 and 100 per cent, respectively, for November. Of the 508-km corridor, 156 km of the track lies in Maharashtra, 4 km in Dadra and Nagar Haveli and 348 km in Gujarat. In addition, all contracts have been awarded in Gujarat and Dadra and Nagar Haveli for civil works, bridges and tracks for the construction of viaducts, other bridges, stations and tracks for the entire alignment.

Launched in September 2017 by PM Narendra Modi and his Japanese counterpart, late Shinzo Abe, the project was expected to be completed by 2023. However, due to delays in land acquisition in Maharashtra and the pandemic, the deadline was extended. The trial run of the first bullet train is planned on the 50-km stretch between Surat and Bilimora in 2026. Financial bids for the design and construction of the Bandra Kurla Complex (BKC) station of the corridor were opened on December 29. “The financial bids of three techni-



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THE NEED FOR SPEED

Initially expected to be completed by 2023, the bullet train project has been delayed by three years due to hurdles in land acquisition

LENGTH

- ▶ Total **508 km**
- ▶ Gujarat **348 km**
- ▶ Dadra and Nagar Haveli **4 km**
- ▶ Maharashtra **156 km**

PROJECT COST

- ▶ Initial cost **₹1.08 lakh crore**

PROJECT FUNDING

- ▶ **80 per cent as easy loan** from Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) at **0.1 per cent interest rate**

TECH AND SPEED

- ▶ Shinkansen (translates to ‘new trunk line’)
- ▶ Max speed **320 kmph**

STATIONS

- ▶ Total stations **12**
- ▶ **Gujarat:** Eight—Vapi, Bilimora, Surat, Bharuch, Vadodara, Anand/Nadiad, Ahmedabad and Sabarmati
- ▶ **Maharashtra:** Four—Mumbai-BKC, Thane, Virar and Boisar
- ▶ Duration: **2.07 hrs** with limited stops; **2.58 hrs** with all stops

cally qualified bidders were opened on December 29, with Megha Engineering & Infrastructures and Hindustan Construction Company JV quoting the lowest bid,” an NHSRCL spokesperson told BT.

Technical bids will be opened for evaluation of tenders filed for the double line (21 km) between BKC station and Shilphata in January. Tenders were also invited for civil and building works involving viaduct, bridges, tunnel, maintenance depot with three stations of Thane, Virar and Boisar, and some connecting works for Thane Depot between Shilphata and Zaroli village on the Gujarat-Maharashtra border (135

km) on November 15 that will be opened for evaluation on March 15.

Despite the challenges, observers continue to remain bullish about the project. “It is important that this project gets followed by future corridors getting developed so that a high-speed rail network emerges over the next decade. A faster and cleaner mode of transportation like the bullet train will lay a sustainable foundation for a growing economy like India,” says Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Director & Practice Leader for Transport & Logistics at CRISIL Infrastructure Advisory. **BT**

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